

The Gaza War

October 7, the IDF Campaign, and the Humanitarian Catastrophe Reshaping the Middle East

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Executive Summary

The Hamas attack of October 7, 2023 constitutes the most catastrophic single-day assault on Jewish life since the Holocaust — a characterisation offered by Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in his address to the Knesset that same day and subsequently affirmed by international Holocaust remembrance bodies. The operation, which Hamas designated "Al-Aqsa Flood," killed approximately 1,200 Israeli and foreign nationals and resulted in the abduction of 251 hostages into the Gaza Strip. The Israeli Defence Forces responded with what became one of the most intensive urban military campaigns of the 21st century, resulting in over 40,000 Palestinian deaths by mid-2024 according to the Gaza Health Ministry — a figure the United Nations accepted as broadly consistent with available epidemiological evidence. The United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees (UNRWA) documented the displacement of over 85% of Gaza's pre-war population of approximately 2.1–2.3 million people. The International Court of Justice (ICJ) issued provisional measures in January 2024 following South Africa's genocide case, while the International Criminal Court (ICC) issued arrest warrants for Israeli Prime Minister Netanyahu and Defence Minister Gallant in November 2024. A first-phase ceasefire agreement reached on January 19, 2025 provided for the exchange of 33 Israeli hostages for approximately 1,900 Palestinian prisoners, pausing but not terminating the military campaign. The conflict fundamentally disrupted the regional normalization architecture that had been advancing under the Abraham Accords framework, triggered a cascade of proxy escalations across Lebanon, Yemen, and Iraq, and produced a humanitarian catastrophe described by UN officials as among the worst of the 21st century.

Part I — October 7: The Hamas Operation

The attack commenced at 6:29 a.m. on October 7, 2023 — the morning of Simchat Torah, among the most joyous holidays in the Jewish calendar — with a barrage of approximately 5,000 rockets fired from Gaza into southern and central Israel within the first twenty minutes. Simultaneously, an estimated 3,000 Hamas fighters breached the Israeli border fence at more than thirty points, using a combination of explosive charges, bulldozers, motorized paragliders, and motorcycles to penetrate what Israeli security doctrine had designated an "impenetrable" smart fence. The intelligence and tactical failure was total and immediate.

The Nova music festival, a trance and nature gathering held near Kibbutz Re'im, bore the full weight of the initial attack on civilians. Of approximately 3,000 attendees, 364 were killed and an additional 40 taken hostage — the single-largest mass killing at the festival site. The killing at the festival was characterised by an absence of military logic: attendees were pursued across open fields by fighters on motorcycles and killed at close range. Footage retrieved from Hamas fighters' body cameras and GoPro

devices, subsequently verified and released by the IDF, documented the execution-style killings and the abduction of young women, some of whom were subsequently confirmed as sexual assault victims by the UN Special Representative on Sexual Violence in Conflict .

The kibbutz attacks demonstrated systematic planning. Be'eri, a community of approximately 1,200 residents, suffered 130 killed — among the highest per-capita loss of any Israeli community and a toll that included entire families murdered in safe rooms . Kfar Aza lost 64 residents. Nir Oz, a community of approximately 400 people, saw 25% of its residents either killed or taken hostage in a single morning — a proportion without modern parallel in Israeli experience . Nahal Oz military base, adjacent to the border, was overrun; soldiers were killed and several female observers abducted. The kibbutz of Holit, Alumim, and Kissufim suffered attacks of varying intensity. The total toll of 1,200 killed included Israeli citizens, dual nationals, and foreign workers — among them Thai agricultural labourers, Filipino caregivers, and Nepali students, representing over 30 nationalities .

The 251 hostages included individuals ranging from infants to Holocaust survivors in their eighties. The demographic breadth of the hostage pool — elderly people dragged from wheelchairs, young children separated from parents, foreign nationals with no political connection to the Israeli-Palestinian conflict — was immediately recognised by Israeli and international observers as a deliberate Hamas strategy to maximise psychological leverage and complicate any military response.

The Israeli intelligence failure was acknowledged with unusual candour by Shin Bet (the internal security service) and Aman (military intelligence). Internal assessments leaked to Haaretz and subsequently confirmed by official inquiries indicated that Hamas had presented intelligence services with what was interpreted as a "conceptziah" — a conceptual frame, similar to the intelligence failure preceding the 1973 Yom Kippur War, that led analysts to discount warning signs . Hamas had conducted elaborate deceptions: publicly signalling a preference for economic de-escalation through the entry of Gazan workers into Israel, while simultaneously running multi-year military exercises that closely mimicked the October 7 operation but were interpreted by Aman as defensive training. The operational planning for "Al-Aqsa Flood," including the assault on the Nova festival and the kibbutz grid, was later assessed to have been in development for at least two years .

Netanyahu's emergency war cabinet convened within hours of the attack and included Defence Minister Yoav Gallant, former IDF Chief of Staff Benny Gantz (brought in from opposition), and former National Security Advisor Gadi Eisenkot. The inclusion of opposition figures was designed to confer national unity legitimacy on a government whose hard-right coalition partners — Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich and National Security Minister Itamar Ben Gvir — were widely seen domestically and internationally as extremist figures whose presence in a war cabinet would be untenable.

Part II — IDF Military Campaign

The IDF campaign unfolded across what military analysts identified as five distinguishable operational phases, though IDF doctrine referred to a "four-phase" framework .

The first phase, from October 7 to October 27, consisted of an intensive air preparation campaign. The IDF dropped approximately 6,000 bombs on Gaza in the first week alone — a pace of bombardment that exceeded the initial phases of the US campaigns in Afghanistan (2001) and Iraq (2003) in terms of munitions per square kilometre of target area . The targeting logic combined known Hamas military infrastructure (tunnels, rocket production facilities, command nodes) with the residential and institutional structures above them, producing destruction of civilian buildings at a scale that immediately attracted international legal scrutiny.

The ground invasion commenced on October 27, 2023, with two armoured divisions advancing into northern Gaza from the northeast and east. The stated IDF military objectives were the destruction of

Hamas's military capacity and the return of the hostages. The northern thrust concentrated on Gaza City, the densely built urban core that Hamas had fortified over two decades through a network of tunnels estimated by IDF intelligence at 500+ kilometres in extent and up to 60 metres in depth .

The battles in and around Jabaliya refugee camp, one of the most densely populated areas on Earth and home to a population of over 100,000 in a geographic footprint of approximately one square kilometre, produced some of the conflict's most intense urban warfare. UN OCHA documented multiple strikes on the camp and its immediate surroundings, noting that the density of the environment meant that even precision munitions would produce mass civilian casualties . The battle for Shifa Hospital became a focal point of international controversy: Israel maintained that Hamas had constructed a major command and control centre beneath the hospital complex, a claim substantiated in part by the subsequent discovery of tunnels beneath the facility, though the IDF's assertion that it constituted Hamas's "main headquarters" was disputed by independent journalists and medical staff who had been present in the hospital in the weeks before the ground operation .

The Khan Yunis campaign, running from December 2023 through February 2024, targeted what IDF intelligence assessed as the primary command structure of Hamas's military wing in southern Gaza. This phase resulted in the operational disruption of several Hamas brigades but failed to neutralise the senior leadership, including Yahya Sinwar, who remained in the tunnel network throughout.

The Rafah ground operation, commencing May 7, 2024, represented the most diplomatically contested phase of the campaign. Approximately 1.4–1.5 million displaced Palestinians had concentrated in the Rafah governorate, a city with a pre-war population of 280,000, following IDF evacuation orders from northern and central Gaza. The Biden administration, facing acute domestic and international political pressure, paused deliveries of 2,000-pound bombs and 500-pound bombs to Israel in May 2024, citing concerns about their deployment in the densely populated Rafah corridor — the first such pause in the conflict . This pause was lifted in August 2024 following what US officials described as Israeli assurances about usage protocols.

By August 2024, the Gaza Health Ministry's cumulative death toll exceeded 40,000 — a figure that UN officials, epidemiologists, and international health organisations accepted as consistent with available evidence, noting that the true toll including deaths from disease, starvation, and lack of medical care was likely substantially higher . UNRWA documented over 85% of the population as displaced, with the majority having been displaced multiple times as successive evacuation orders compressed civilians into progressively smaller geographic zones. Satellite analysis conducted by Corey Scher at the City University of New York's Graduate Center, using PlanetScope and Copernicus imagery, documented the destruction of over 75% of structures in northern Gaza — a level of physical devastation comparable to the destruction of Dresden in 1945 or Grozny in 1999–2000 .

Part III — International Legal and Diplomatic Response

South Africa filed a case against Israel under the Genocide Convention at the International Court of Justice on December 29, 2023, invoking Article IX of the Convention and requesting urgent provisional measures . The application argued that Israel's conduct of the military campaign — including statements by senior Israeli officials referencing historical frameworks of collective punishment and dehumanising language toward Palestinians — constituted plausible evidence of genocidal intent, a legal threshold below the evidentiary standard for a final genocide determination.

The ICJ delivered its provisional measures order on January 26, 2024. The Court, ruling 15–2, ordered Israel to take all measures within its power to prevent genocidal acts under Article II of the Genocide Convention, to ensure its military forces do not commit genocidal acts, to prevent and punish direct and public incitement to genocide, and to enable the provision of humanitarian assistance . Critically, the

Court did not order a ceasefire and did not find that genocide had been established — the provisional measures order was explicitly predicated on the lower "plausibility" standard required for such relief. Nicaragua subsequently joined the proceedings, and Bangladesh and Mali indicated intention to intervene. The Gambia, which had previously brought a Genocide Convention case against Myanmar, filed a declaration of intervention.

The ICC proceedings moved on a parallel track. Prosecutor Karim Khan announced on May 20, 2024 that he was seeking arrest warrants against both Israeli and Hamas leaders, establishing a moral and legal equivalence that was politically explosive in Western capitals . Khan's applications cited "reasonable grounds" to believe that Netanyahu and Gallant had committed war crimes including the starvation of civilians as a method of warfare, wilful killing, wilfully causing great suffering, intentional attacks against civilians, and other inhumane acts. The Hamas leaders targeted — Yahya Sinwar, Mohammed Deif, and Ismail Haniyeh — faced charges including murder, torture, hostage-taking, and sexual violence in the context of the October 7 attacks.

The ICC Pre-Trial Chamber issued the warrants for Netanyahu and Gallant on November 21, 2024, specifically citing crimes against humanity including the use of starvation as a weapon of war . The warrants created immediate obligations on the 124 ICC member states to arrest the named individuals if they travelled to their territory — a constraint with practical implications for Israeli diplomatic travel and an unprecedented legal exposure for a sitting prime minister of a US-allied democracy. The United States, which is not an ICC member state, condemned the warrants as "outrageous." Several European ICC member states, including France and the Netherlands, indicated complex legal uncertainty about the warrants' applicability to a head of state of a non-ICC member state.

At the UN Security Council, the United States exercised its veto power on four separate ceasefire resolutions between October 2023 and March 2024 . The March 25, 2024 resolution, which called for an immediate ceasefire in Gaza, passed after the United States abstained rather than vetoing — the first time the US had permitted a ceasefire resolution to pass during the conflict, a diplomatic shift that reflected mounting White House frustration with Israeli conduct and the political pressures of a US presidential election year .

The humanitarian aid situation became a subject of intense international focus. UN agencies determined that Gaza required a minimum of 200 trucks of humanitarian aid per day to prevent acute famine conditions, against an actual delivery rate fluctuating between 50 and 100 trucks per day across the conflict's peak phases . The UNRWA faced its own crisis when Israel provided evidence to several donor governments that 12 UNRWA staff members had participated in the October 7 attack, with 17 total accused. The United States suspended all UNRWA funding in January 2024, and several European states temporarily reduced or suspended funding pending independent investigation .

Part IV — Regional Escalation Cascade

The conflict immediately activated the broader architecture of Iran's "axis of resistance" — the network of proxy forces that Tehran had constructed and maintained across Lebanon, Gaza, Yemen, Iraq, and Syria. From October 8, 2023 onwards, Hezbollah in Lebanon exchanged fire with Israel daily along the Lebanese border, transforming the northern border into a low-to-medium intensity front that displaced approximately 60,000 Israelis from border communities in the Galilee and compelled the Israeli government to accept that the pre-war normalcy of northern Israel was indefinitely suspended .

The escalation on the Lebanon front reached a qualitative inflection point in September 2024. On September 17 and 18, 2024, pager and walkie-talkie devices used by Hezbollah operatives across Lebanon detonated simultaneously, killing at least 32 Hezbollah members and injuring approximately 3,000 in an operation widely attributed to Israeli intelligence . The attack, unprecedented in scope and

execution, was interpreted by analysts as Israel's most significant penetration of Hezbollah's operational communications since the organisation's founding. It was followed on September 27, 2024 by an Israeli airstrike on Hezbollah's headquarters in the Dahieh district of southern Beirut that killed Hassan Nasrallah, the Secretary-General of Hezbollah who had led the organisation since 1992 — the most consequential targeted killing of a regional actor since the US killing of Qasem Soleimani in January 2020. A limited IDF ground incursion into south Lebanon followed in October 2024, and a US-France brokered ceasefire was announced on November 27, 2024, providing for a 60-day initial cessation of hostilities and the withdrawal of IDF forces and Hezbollah beyond established buffer zones.

The Houthi movement in Yemen, operating under the banner of solidarity with Gaza, began attacking commercial shipping in the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden from November 2023, claiming to target Israeli-linked vessels but in practice striking a broader range of international shipping. The campaign effectively disrupted Red Sea shipping lanes that carry approximately 15% of global trade and compelled major container shipping firms to reroute around the Cape of Good Hope, adding 10–14 days and substantial cost to European-Asian supply chains. The United States and United Kingdom began conducting strikes against Houthi military infrastructure in Yemen from January 12, 2024, without substantially degrading the Houthi capacity to sustain their campaign.

Iran's most direct intervention came on April 13–14, 2024, when the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps launched an unprecedented direct attack on Israeli territory involving over 300 drones, cruise missiles, and ballistic missiles — the first direct Iranian military strike on Israel in history. The IDF and the US, UK, Jordanian, and Saudi air defence systems intercepted approximately 99% of the incoming projectiles. Israel responded with a limited strike on Isfahan on April 19, 2024, targeting air defence radar infrastructure rather than nuclear facilities — a carefully calibrated response designed to demonstrate Israeli reach into Iranian territory without triggering a second Iranian escalation.

Yahya Sinwar, the architect of October 7 and Hamas's supreme leader in Gaza, was killed in an IDF ground operation in Rafah on October 17, 2024, discovered by IDF soldiers in a tunnel structure where he appeared to have been in the final stages of active combat rather than attempting escape — a death that eliminated Hamas's primary decision-maker and complicated the hostage negotiations that had been ongoing through Qatari, Egyptian, and US intermediaries.

The Phase 1 ceasefire agreement, announced on January 19, 2025, provided for a six-week initial phase in which 33 Israeli hostages — including women, elderly individuals, and those with medical conditions — would be exchanged for approximately 1,900 Palestinian prisoners held in Israeli jails. President Biden, Secretary of State Blinken, and President-elect Trump all publicly claimed varying degrees of credit for the agreement, reflecting the political significance both administrations attached to the resolution.

Part V — Humanitarian Crisis and Accountability

Gaza's pre-war human geography presented one of the most acute humanitarian environments in the world even before October 7. A population of 2.1–2.3 million people was contained within 365 square kilometres — a population density comparable to Singapore, but without Singapore's infrastructure, economic base, or freedom of movement. The blockade maintained by Israel and Egypt since Hamas took power in 2007 had produced chronic shortages of construction materials, medical equipment, and economic opportunity, with youth unemployment in Gaza exceeding 60% in the years preceding the conflict.

The displacement of 85%+ of Gaza's population into progressively smaller zones produced a concentration of human misery without contemporary parallel. At its peak, approximately 1.4–1.5 million people — five times the pre-war population of Rafah — were compressed into an area intended to house 280,000, living in improvised shelters, UNRWA school buildings, and open ground with minimal

sanitation, food, and water . The United Nations Integrated Food Security Phase Classification (IPC) declared North Gaza in Phase 5 — the highest category, designated "Catastrophic" — in February 2024, the first time any area in the Middle East had received this designation and only the second globally active IPC Phase 5 classification at that time .

The medical system collapsed progressively through the conflict. The World Health Organisation documented that by August 2024, only 12 of Gaza's pre-war 36 hospitals remained partially functional — operating in conditions of extreme scarcity of medicines, fuel, surgical supplies, and staff . At least 500 healthcare workers were killed during the conflict, including doctors, nurses, and paramedics who continued working in facilities that were struck by munitions while under the protection of international humanitarian law . Médecins Sans Frontières documented the deaths of multiple MSF staff members in strikes on facilities and convoys that had been coordinated with Israeli military officials.

The toll on journalists constitutes one of the most historically significant accountability dimensions of the conflict. The Committee to Protect Journalists documented over 100 journalists killed in Gaza by mid-2024, making this the highest journalist death toll in any single conflict in the organisation's recorded history, which extends to the 1990s . The deaths included both Gazan journalists covering the conflict for local and international outlets and international journalists killed in identified media convoys.

The World Central Kitchen incident of April 1, 2024 — in which seven international aid workers, including an Australian, a Polish national, a British-Canadian dual national, and other non-Gazan nationals were killed in three sequential strikes on clearly marked World Central Kitchen vehicles — became a global inflection point for international opinion . The organisation had coordinated its convoy route with IDF officials, as confirmed by both WCK and the IDF. Prime Minister Netanyahu described the killing as "unintentional" and the result of a targeting error . The IDF subsequently dismissed two officers and reprimanded others following an internal investigation. The incident, combined with the accumulated humanitarian toll, substantially accelerated the erosion of international support for Israel's military campaign in European capitals that had initially expressed solidarity with Israel following October 7.

Conclusion

The Gaza War of 2023–2025 has emerged as the defining regional crisis of the 2020s in the Middle East — a conflict that simultaneously exposes the fragility of humanitarian norms in high-intensity urban warfare, the limits of Western diplomatic leverage over US allies, and the structural impossibility of resolving the Palestinian question through military means alone. The two-state solution, which international consensus had nominally maintained as the framework for Israeli-Palestinian peace since Oslo in 1993, was functionally extinguished as a near-term possibility: the Palestinian Authority under 88-year-old Mahmoud Abbas lacks the governance capacity, legitimacy, or security footprint to administer a post-war Gaza, while Hamas, though militarily degraded, retained organisational presence throughout the campaign. The question of Gaza's post-war governance — the "day after" problem — remained unresolved as of mid-2026, with no viable administration willing and able to assume authority. Israeli domestic politics, polarised between a hard-right coalition committed to open-ended occupation and a centre-left opposition demanding early elections and a hostage deal at any cost, precluded strategic clarity. The regional normalization architecture — the Abraham Accords framework and the Saudi normalization process — was suspended. Iran emerged from the conflict with its proxy network attenuated but its nuclear programme further advanced and less monitored. The war's accountability dimension, embodied in the ICC warrants and ICJ proceedings, will shape Israeli diplomatic exposure for decades. The fundamental disorder introduced into the Middle East order by October 7 remains, a year and more later, without resolution.

